THE CODEX TRILOGY

Book One

Working draft

Caribbean, 1690

CHAPTER 1

The Temple

Two days into the storm, Bonesy was getting nowhere with Beatriz.

He stood in front of her with what he had in place of a hand resting on her stone shoulder. He had drawn a heart in the dust between them on the first morning. He had drawn an arrow through it on the second. The arrow had wandered because his foot kept getting in the way, and now the arrow had two points and no shaft, which he had told us was a metaphor and we had not asked him for. Beatriz did not return his looks. Beatriz had not returned anyone's looks in nine hundred years, but the fact of this had never been brought up to Bonesy in any way he would respect.

"You've been quiet today," he said to her.

The wind hauled into the headland above the temple's mouth, and a branch came down off the upper stones and skidded down the slope in pieces. The lamp Crumble had wedged between two broken slabs guttered. The shadows of the chamber moved.

"I noticed," Bonesy said.

I had been on the windward end of what remained of a stone bench for an hour, working a knot out of a length of cord with my teeth, listening to the storm and to him. We were in the back room of an old Maya temple that had given up at the front a long time ago. The front had come down at the doorway in stones and the stones had grown over in vines, and the door was a mouth now. The chamber behind the mouth was lower than a man's reach and four long paces deep, and at this hour of an afternoon, with the weather what it was, it was dark enough that Crumble had lit the lamp. The lamp gave us back a little of the day. It lit the carvings in the band along the walls well enough that a man could read them, if a man knew how, and Crumble did. It lit the three of us, and the three of us in that light looked like three men of dignity, which we were not.

Crumble was against the south wall with a leather pouch open in his lap. He had taken a tobacco leaf out of the pouch some time before and was working a corner of it slow in the back of his cheek, the way Balam had taught him, the way the people of this country had done before the Spanish ever came and dried the leaf and rolled it into sticks. He had a chart laid across his thighs to pass the time. He had been reading it for two days. He read charts the way a priest reads a scripture, in the small steady way of a man who is not in a hurry and does not feel he is being watched. He had closed his eyes some time back without leaving the chart there, which was his way of saying he did not want to be talked to. I knew the look. I had known it seven years.

I should say, on Bonesy.

Bonesy was a skeleton.

He had been a man before he had been a skeleton. By his own account he had been a Maya man, from a town he could no longer find on a map and no longer wanted to. He had not been anyone of

importance, in his time. He had worked a patch of corn ground. He had not been a priest. He had not been the son of a priest. The priests of his town had not let him near anything they did not want everyone to see, and that had stayed with him ever since. He could not say how long ago that had been, exactly. He had been a skeleton a long time. He had not aged in any way I could see, which was the part of him that took some getting used to, and the part of him that, once you were used to it, made him hard to think about clearly. He stood a little under my height. He had nothing on him except a leather cord around his neck. He had been with Crumble and me about a year, attached the way a stray attaches to a fire, and we had stopped trying to put him anywhere else.

He talked to Beatriz the way a man talks to a wife he has been married to too long and not long enough.

"I made a list," he said. "Things I appreciate about you. Things I find difficult."

Crumble, without opening his eyes, said, "She's a corn god."

"She is what I say she is."

"He."

"She is a goddess."

"He's a god of corn. He has the husk on his brow."

"That's hair."

"It's a husk."

"She has lovely hair."

"He is bald under a husk."

"Beatriz," Bonesy said, "tell him."

Beatriz did not.

The wind eased a notch and the lamp steadied. The lords of the underworld watched from the band along the upper wall, where they had been watching for nine hundred years. There were thirteen of

them, by Crumble's count. They had their hands folded in front of them. They had not blinked, in the time of any man in this chamber but one, and that one not by much.

Two and a half days back we had walked out of a Spanish fort at the edge of Veracruz with nothing for our trouble. The hire wanted a finger. Not any finger. The finger of a small Castilian saint who had died half a century back at a mission in Yucatán, kept now in a reliquary of gilt silver in the lower vaults, which we had taken to be one vault and had found, on getting in, to be several. There was time to crack one. Not several. I had read the sky off the high wall on the way in. The sky was wrong by an hour, in the direction that does not let you bargain with it. Crumble wanted to go down anyway. I said no. He said yes, and then he said yes once more, more quietly, which was him telling me he had heard me. The quartermaster on the south wall had given his face a longer look than I wanted to think about, and his corporal a longer one. We had not run on the way out. We had walked. We had put the sloop three hours west with the first edge of the squall already on our shoulders and tucked her into a pass we had kept in our pocket for years, between two outflung arms of stone where the surge runs up the outer arm and breaks on it and never makes the inner. The cove behind the arms was the reason the cove existed, and the reason we knew of it. She had been holding for two days. She was holding now. She was also coming out from under cover, by the hour, as the storm let up. The two were one fact looked at from two sides.

Bonesy turned his skull a quarter to look at me. He turned it the way a man does not turn his head. There is a way the head sits on a man, with the muscles of the neck holding it, and it does not move that way on its own. Bonesy's slid round on the spine the way a stone slides on a table when the table tips. He had a kind of decency about

it. He did it slowly. He gave you time to take it in.

"Jigsaw."

"Yes."

"Tell him she's a rain goddess."

"She's a rain goddess."

"There," he said to Crumble. "Quorum."

"You bribed him."

"He volunteered."

"He always volunteers."

"He is loyal in his way."

"He is bored in his way."

I let them go. I was listening. The squall had been blowing two days out of the east-southeast and was tired now. A gale wears itself out the way a man does. In pulls and pauses. Getting more honest at the end about how it cannot keep this up forever. I could hear the headland breaking the worst of it. I could hear the cove sounding fine in the easing.

The wind drew in a long breath. Held it. Let it out a touch softer than the breath before.

There.

"It's hauling round," I said.

Crumble opened his eyes.

"How long."

"Few hours. Teeth come out, then it'll quiet by first light."

He nodded. He closed his eyes. He took another small piece off the leaf.

"A shame," Bonesy said. "We were making progress."

"You were making progress," Crumble said.

"It is a partnership."

"It is a wall."

“Hard women are like that.”

“She is a wall.”

“They take time.”

Crumble’s mouth almost moved. He held it. He took another piece of the leaf.

Bonesy bent down. The bones of his knees made the sound of a man cracking walnuts. He picked up a small piece of broken stone from the floor, considered it, set it on the heart in the dust as if he were laying a wreath, and stood up again. The same sound on the way up.

“So,” he said. He was looking at the wall. He was talking to the wall, which is what he did when he was talking to us. “The old priests used to talk about a book.”

I did not stop working the cord. Crumble’s jaw did.

“They used to sit in their cellars,” Bonesy said. “Not the cellars they cleaned for the festivals. The ones in the back. They didn’t want me down there. They never said so. They just looked at me a certain way and shifted their bones around. I went in anyway. I’d sit on a barrel. I’d ask questions. They’d pretend they didn’t hear me. They’d talk to each other about a book that wasn’t a book anymore because they had taken it apart on purpose. They’d argue about whose grandfather had touched a corner of it. Whose grandfather’s grandfather had. They could never agree. They’d argue all night. They could never get rid of me. It was the only thing they could never get rid of.”

He picked up another small piece of stone. He set it next to the first one.

“It was an interesting book,” he said. “By the sound of it.”

The wind eased another notch.

Crumble had not opened his eyes. He had stopped chewing. That was all I needed to know.

“Balam used to talk about it,” he said.

Bonesy did not turn round.

“Did he.”

“Yes.”

“Did he have one of the pieces.”

“He was working on one. Before he went.”

“Which one.”

Crumble was a long time answering. He chewed the leaf and looked at the lamp.

“He said it was off a half-moon island,” he said. “He said the cave was hid by a thing the old priests couldn’t put a name to. He said it works the way certain weather does. A man on the shore wouldn’t see the cave. He’d see a pool.”

“He’d see a pool,” Bonesy said.

“Yes.”

I let the cord lie still in my hands.

“Tarpon,” I said.

Crumble’s eyes opened.

“What.”

“There’s tarpon in a pool on the windward side of a half-moon island west of the Bay of Honduras. Six and seven feet of them. They slide past each other on a current the pool has got no business having. Water no deeper than my waist. They don’t turn off when a man comes up on them. I crouched on the stone five years back and put my hand in the water. They went past my hand. They went past it slow.”

The chamber went quiet the way a chamber does when the wind that has been working at it for two days finally lets up.

“Jigsaw.”

“I know, Crumble.”

“Jigsaw.”

“I’ve been there.”

He closed his eyes again. He did not look surprised. He looked like a man who had been holding his breath without knowing it and had only just been able to let it out.

I had stood at the edge of that pool five years back. I had been twenty. The water behind the tarpon had not stopped moving the way a small shallow pool’s water stops, when the wind quits and there is no reason for it to keep on. The water had been pulling somewhere I could not see. I had stood and watched it the better part of an hour. I had got into the dinghy and gone home. I had not spoken of it to Crumble. I had not spoken of it to anyone. I had been telling myself for five years that someday I would go back.

Bonesy made a noise. We looked at him.

“What.”

“Nothing. Carry on.”

“Bonesy.”

“I am very moved. Don’t mind me. Beatriz is moved. We are both moved. Carry on.”

“Bonesy.”

“What.”

“Sit down.”

He sat down in front of Beatriz. He took her, gently, off her base, and set her in his lap, and stared at the wall.

Outside, the storm came down off its peak and the wind hauled another quarter. The air in the chamber had changed. There is a way air changes in a small room when three men in it have been quiet for two days and one of them has finally said the thing the other two

were waiting for. The lamp does not light it any differently. It sits a little heavier on the shoulders, is all.

“We can’t leave it,” Crumble said. He was saying it to himself.

“No,” I said. “We can’t.”

The lamp guttered. The lords of the underworld in their row watched, as they had been, and would.

Bonesy stepped on the heart in the dust by accident, and stepped off it carefully, the way a man does when he doesn’t want to admit he’s done damage.

“Beatriz,” he said. “I am about to have an adventure. Try not to take it personally.”

Beatriz did not.

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The storm went the way I said it would. The teeth came out of it past midnight, a few hard hours throwing what it had left against the headland, and then by the grey before first light it had spent itself and gone north to be some other coast’s trouble. I had slept the way I sleep on a job, in pieces, with one ear out, and when the chamber stopped flinching I came all the way awake and lay listening to the cove. The surge had come down. The pass was talking quietly to itself the way it does on a falling sea. She had taken the whole blow without complaint, which is the most you can ask of a boat and more than you can ask of most men.

Crumble was already up, sitting against the south wall with his hands loose on his knees, looking at nothing, which was him being ready to go an hour before there was anything to go to. He had not slept much. I could see it and I left it. There are men you ask after and men you leave to find their own bottom, and Crumble has been

the second kind since we were boys.

Bonesy had Beatriz in his lap still. He had not put her back on her base.

I got up and stretched the night out of my back. The chamber in the grey light was a smaller, poorer place than it had been by the lamp. The lords on the wall had gone flat, just scratches in old stone, and Beatriz in his lap was a corn god with a chip out of his brow, and the heart in the dust had been walked through so many times in the night it was only dust again. That is the way of places. They are large in the dark and keep their size only as long as you are afraid of them.

“We’ll want to be off her by full light,” I said. “She’s been under cover two days and the cover’s gone. Anybody who came up out of the south after the blow with a glass and an hour of clear sky finds a hull where there’s meant to be none.”

“You think the fort sent word,” Crumble said.

“I think the quartermaster looked at your face longer than a man looks at a face he means to forget. I don’t think past that. But I don’t want to be the hull he finds.”

Crumble nodded and got himself up the wall to standing, and stood with his hand flat over his coat where the chart was, and I knew he had the half-moon island in his hand the way I had it in mine. West and a little south. Six days with the wind in its right quarter. The pool. The door I stood at when I was twenty and did not go through.

Here is a thing about me I will set down because it matters to what came after. I wanted to go. Not the way Crumble wanted to go. Crumble wanted it because of Balam, because a dead man set it in his hands and dying men’s wishes are the heaviest things there are. I wanted it because I have spent my life on the top of the water wondering what the water was keeping from me, and here at last was

a door down into it, and I have wanted to go through that door since before I had a word for wanting. The gold was real and I'll not pretend it wasn't. But under the gold was the door, and under the door the thing I have never been able to name and have been chasing up and down these islands since I was a boy, and I knew if I let it, the wanting would put us on the wrong reef with the wrong gear and end us.

So I was the one who said it.

"We can't sail for it like this."

He looked at me.

"We've a finger we didn't get. No pay for it, because there's no pay till it's in the man's hand. Two days of water in the hold. We go through that door like this and we come up the way Balam came up. Old, broke, and not finished. I'd rather go a month late and go right."

His jaw set. Something moved behind his eyes and was put away, and I knew the shape of it, because I'd handed it to him. I'd as good as said he'd run us at the thing half-cocked if I let him, that the man Balam made couldn't be trusted to wait. He didn't answer it. He let it sit in him. That is the way of us. There are things we hand each other that neither one says out loud, and they go in, and they stay in, and you find them again years later still where you put them.

"So Tortuga," he said. "It's the wrong heading."

"It's the wrong heading and the right order. East before west. We get the finger to the man, we get paid, we fit her out, then we point her at your old man's island with a full hold and a clean name. We don't go down empty."

"We've nothing to put in front of him," Crumble said. "We walked out of that fort with our hands as bare as we walked in. There's no pay for empty hands."

"No," I said. "There isn't."

And there it was, the plan dead on the floor before it could stand, because the man only pays for the finger, and the finger was in a vault under a Spanish courtyard three hours east of us with a lid on it.

Which is when Bonesy set Beatriz down off his lap, gentle, and stood.

“I’ve been waiting two days for one of you to get to that part,” he said.

He reached to the cord at his neck. There was a thinner cord run through the thick one, that I had not marked in a year of looking at him, and he drew it up over the knobs of his spine and held the end of it out into the grey coming through the vines.

A finger hung off it. Bone, yellow-brown, longer in the joint than my own, worn smooth at the knuckle the way a thing gets worn by a great many hands that thought touching it would do them good.

Neither of us moved. I have been in a great many rooms when the thing in them changed, and I knew the room had changed, and I was half a step behind it, which does not happen to me often and which I did not enjoy.

“That’s the finger,” Crumble said, the way you say a word in a dream. “That’s the saint. That’s the pay.”

“That’s the pay,” said Bonesy.

“You’ve had it.”

“Since the cellar. While you two were up in the courtyard reading the sky at each other, I went and had a look at the part of the fort you were so sure we’d no time for.” He turned the bone on its cord. “Nobody minds me on a stair. Nobody shoots at a thing they take for a trick of the lamp. I went down where the dead ones were kept. There was a little gold house, very fine, and her shut up inside it in the dark where nobody could so much as say good morning to her.” He looked at the finger, and for a moment he was not playing to us.

“I’ve been in a gold house. I didn’t care for it. So I took her out and left them the box.”

“Two days,” Crumble said. “We sat in this rock two days sick over it. You watched us.”

“You were very sad. It was educational.” He tilted his skull. “And had I shown you in the courtyard you’d have wanted the box as well, and we’d all three be living in the box now.”

The laugh came up out of Crumble before he could stop it, low and cracked and not rightly knowing if it was a laugh or the other thing, and he sat back against the wall with it and put the heel of his hand to his eye. I felt it climb in me too, the foulness and the relief together, two days of mourning turned in one stroke into two days of a skeleton wearing our pay round his neck and watching us grieve. There is a kind of luck so rotten and so good at once that the only thing a man can do with it is laugh.

But the anger was still in Crumble under it, the two days of it, and it had its say once the laugh thinned.

“You let us sit in it, you bony bastard. Two whole days.”

“I did. I’d have done three.” He was not sorry. He does not get sorry. “You learn things about men, watching them think they’ve lost.”

“He’s right, though,” Crumble said to me, and the laugh was gone out of his voice now, just the plain fact of it left. “Not about the three days. About the rest. We’d not have got within a wall of that cellar and you know it. They’d have had us on the stair. He walks down there and he’s a shadow, a ball goes through him and it’s a hole in the air, a sea that drowns us is weather to him. He goes where we can’t and he doesn’t even have to be brave about it. He just goes.” He looked at Bonesy and said it level, the way a man says a thing he means and wants heard: “We’ve no hope of that island without you.

None.”

I watched Bonesy take it.

He went still in a way he does not usually go still, the performing gone clean off him for a breath, the skull level, the empty of him turned full on Crumble. He has been a long time among people who’d not have cared if he lay down in a ditch and stopped, and you don’t lose that the way you lose a smell off your clothes. Then he gathered himself back up into something he could carry.

“Yes,” he said. “Well. One of us has to be of use.”

But he’d heard it. I saw him hear it.

“So we get her to the man,” I said, to give him somewhere to put it. “He’s at Tortuga, or his people are. We hand her over, we get paid, we fit her out, and we go.”

Bonesy looked down at the finger against his front.

“We hand her over,” he said.

“That’s the job.”

“He’ll house her again. Your man. He didn’t pay to set a saint loose in the air. He paid to have her in a box of his own instead of a box of theirs.” He turned her on the cord, slow. “Out of one gold house and into the next. That’s the whole of what we’ve done for her.”

“It’s the whole of what we were paid to do,” I said.

“I know it.” And he did. He stopped turning her and let her rest against the front of him, and he did not argue it, and that was the thing I marked, because Bonesy argues everything, it is the one labor he never tires of, and he did not argue this. He just looked at her a moment longer than the joke wanted. Then he ran the thin cord back down inside the thick one and settled her out of sight, and the matter was closed, and he was the practical thing again.

We left the way you leave a place you don't mean to see again and don't want to make a thing of. Crumble stopped at the mouth and said something low in the old tongue to the wall, that I didn't have and wasn't meant to. Bonesy stopped by Beatriz. He stood over her a moment, set her square on her base facing out the way she'd faced nine hundred years, and stepped back. He drew no heart. He made no joke.

"Goodbye," he said to her, and went out ahead of us into the morning, and did not look back at her, and did not touch the cord at his neck, though I half thought he would.

The storm had scrubbed the morning clean. The sky had gone that hard washed blue it goes after a blow, and the cove was so clear over the white sand you could count the links of her chain from the rocks. She sat in the pass between the two stone arms with her single mast raked back and her hull the colour of a thing built not to be seen, riding to her scope, waiting on us like she'd known all along we'd be back and had better things to think about in the meantime.

I stood on the rock above her and looked past her, out the pass, south and east, the road to Tortuga.

It was empty.

I looked at it a while, the way you look at a thing because its being empty is a kind of luck you have learned not to trust. Then I went down to take us off.

CHAPTER 2

Tortuga

It is six days from that island to Tortuga with the wind in its right quarter, and the wind was not in its right quarter, so it was nine. Nine days is a long while to be penned on a small boat with two men carrying things they will not set down, and a third who sets nothing down because he carries nothing, and fills the quiet with whatever comes into his skull.

It was on the third day that Crumble named whose fort it had been.

We were close-hauled and beating, and he had the tiller, and I was forward working an eye into a line that had chafed through in the blow.

“That garrison was Cárdenas’s,” he said, to the horizon.

I did not stop working the line. I did not need to ask which Cárdenas. There is only the one, for us. We had crossed his people before and carried it on us still, Crumble in a seam of scar under his ribs and me in the habit of counting a Spanish crew twice before I

believed the number. Don Mateo de Cárdenas.

“We robbed a cellar of his,” I said.

“We robbed an empty box out of a cellar of his,” Crumble said. “He’ll have found it by now.”

“A man like that. Finding a box in his own house with the lid up and nothing in it.”

“A man like that,” Crumble agreed, and shifted the tiller a hair to feel the wind, and that was the whole of what we said, because there was nothing to do about it from a small boat six days from anywhere, and because the thing we were not talking about was still louder than Cárdenas, who is a hard thing to be louder than.

We raised Tortuga on the ninth evening, the turtle-back of it black against a sky going the colour of a bruise on the mend, and came into the road under the last light with the canvas down to nothing, the way you come into a place where everyone watching owns a glass and a grudge.

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The sale went easy, the way it goes when you have the saint and the man wants the saint and neither of you is fool enough to pretend otherwise. The hire kept an agent above a cooperage on the harbour front, a round Portuguese named Vaz who smelled of cloves. He took the finger in a square of black cloth and held it to a candle and turned it, and for one breath the cloves and the soft round manner went off him and there was the man underneath who handled saints for a living, and then it came back, and he paid us. He paid us well, the way you pay men you would like to use again and would rather not have annoyed at you. We went down the cooperage stair heavier in the coat than we had been in a year, free of the job, and clean.

Which meant it was time to spend some of it, because a man does not go through a door at the bottom of the sea on the gear he had spare.

We have our own pieces. Those a man does not buy in a port, because a man's own gear is half him by the time it is worth anything, and you do not buy half yourself off a table.

Crumble carries a blade Balam had made for him the year he finished teaching him, a thing shaped older than a cutlass and shorter, straight and broad and squared at the tip, after a pattern the old people used, with a grip wound in dyed leather and a guard worked with the small blocky figures that mean things to Crumble and nothing to me. He wears the old people on him on purpose, panels of worked cloth and plate over the European coat, a sash dyed the deep red they made from a bug and a root, so that he walks into a Spanish room looking like the thing forty years of Cárdenas has been spent trying to scrub off the earth, and he does it knowing exactly what he looks like, which is the bravest small thing I know a man to do daily.

I wear hides, but not the way a man pictures when I say it. Not skins thrown over the shoulder like some hunter come down out of the hills. I wear a pirate's coat and a pirate's rig, cut and stitched the way any man's is on this water, only I built mine, and I built it out of what the sea and the hunt gave me. Hide worked into the facings where the salt eats wool to nothing. Hide at the shoulders and the forearms where a blade looks to land. Hide sewn down over the canvas in panels, oiled dark, so it turns water where canvas drinks it and breathes where wool boils a man in his own sweat. It is mine, every piece of it off an animal I knew the death of, and it has kept the parts of me a man wants kept more times than I can count. To a stranger it reads as a coat that has been somewhere. That is the whole of what I want it to read as.

And I do not carry a cutlass. I carry two Spanish blades, lighter than shipboard iron and quicker in a crowd. They are Toledo in shape, but the steel is older than that in its making: crucible steel, wootz by another name, high-carbon and watered in the Arab fashion, with dark lines running through it when the light catches right.

I learned the Spanish sword before I even knew what Tortuga was, in rooms with swept floors and boys whose fathers had paid for them to stand straight. They called it form. Form is useful until someone is trying to kill you. I learned the rest in back rooms with dirt on the floor and coin underfoot, where steel went where it could reach and no one called it unfair until he was opened.

Needless to say me and Crumble were not going to be buying new swords.

The gear we wanted was the plain kind a man replaces, and we went to get it. Powder, dry, off a Dutchman who kept it dry and charged for the keeping, and a fresh paper of flints to spark it. Cartridge wadding and a ball-mould and bar lead to cast our own. A coil of good hemp and a bolt of canvas for the sailmaker's work that never ends. Pitch and oakum for her seams. Salt pork in the cask and turtle we'd take live and keep on its back in the bilge for fresh meat, and hard biscuit, and a netted sack of limes and another of oranges against the rot that loosens a man's teeth and then takes the rest of him. A breaker of water sweetened with a little rum so it would keep. Crumble went off on his own account and came back with the things no Dutchman stocks, got from the Mayans who keep to the back lanes of any port on this coast. Ground cacao pressed into hard tablets, bitter as bilge and worth more than its weight to a man on a long sail. A twist of dried chiles. Pom, the tree-blood incense the old people burn to their dead, which he did not explain and I did not ask

after. Supplies are supplies, and a man's reasons are his own.

And at a slop-seller's stall with the lamps coming gold along the front, we bought Bonesy a hat. We thought nothing of it. A good one, black felt, broad, the brim stiff, a band of plain dark ribbon, the kind of thing any of the three of us might have wanted off the table, and Crumble paid for it the same as he'd paid for the limes.

Bonesy took it and turned it once in what he has for hands and put it on. Then he stood under it a moment longer than the moment wanted, and put his hand up and touched the brim, just touched it, settling it, the way a man does with a thing that is his.

I had been about to say something idle and did not. In all the time he had been with us, Bonesy had worn nothing, a cord at his neck and that the whole of it, and I had taken it for one of his ways, like the not sleeping, like the talking. It was not a way. A hermit crab will go bare and pinched its whole life before it climbs into a shell that is not its own, and the bare ones do not last. He had been the bare kind. He had stopped looking for a shell so long ago he had forgotten it was a thing a creature could have, and not one of us, in a year, had thought to hand him one.

He did not say anything about it, and neither did I. Some things you carry better unsaid.

We got him a belt too, broad, to take a blade, and hung a short sword on it that he swore he had no use for and kept anyway. He drew the line there. No coat, no boots. A hat, a belt, a blade. Enough that a man across a room would take him for a man and not a haunting, which was further across that line than he had ever stood, and far enough for one night.

Crumble was already pulling his collar up, though it was warm. "I'm away up to find Domingo," he said. "He'll know if the old man left word with anyone but me. He keeps the ears of half the coast and

lends them cheap to people he likes." He looked at me. "He knew Balam. Boys together, before any of it. He goes by Domingo down here because a Maya name in a Spanish port is a thing men collect you for. To me he's not Domingo." He said the other name, soft, with the finish I do not have. "Don't follow me up. He won't open with strangers by, and the two of you are a great deal of strange."

"We'll find a tavern and lower rum," I said. "You'll know us by the wreckage."

He went up the hill into the dark of the town, and I watched him go until I couldn't, the way I always do.

*

Bonesy and I went the other way, down toward the water.

There is not much to Tortuga and there is not meant to be. One front street along the harbour, a scatter of shacks and storehouses climbing the hill behind it, the fort up top, and the whole of it small enough that a man can stand at the seawall and see every place worth going. It is an outpost more than a town, a place men come to spend what they took and take on what they need before they are somewhere else. There is no one kind of man in it. There is the Welshman and the Dutchman and the Frenchman who would cut each other's throats in any harbour that flew a flag worth the name, and the freed man and the run man and the man with no country left to claim him, and the outpost asks none of them where they came from or what they did to need it. That is the whole of its welcome and the whole of its strength. A man walks into Tortuga off any deck under any colours and by the second cup he is no stranger, because the outpost was built to take in exactly the men no other place would.

The French hold it, after a fashion. A governor sits up in the fort under their colours and takes his cut of everything that crosses the harbour, the casks and the captives and every prize sold on the front, and what he gives back for it I have never been able to find. He does not keep the peace; the brethren keep their own. He does not feed the place or defend it past his own wall. He takes his share and signs his papers and flies his flag, and the men on the front let him, the way you let the gulls have the offal, because it is easier than minding them and they were always going to take it anyway.

The heat does not let up after dark here. It only changes its smell. By day the front reeks of tar and gutted fish and the hot stone of the seawall; by night it goes sweeter and worse, rum and woodsmoke and the sugar-rot drifting off the cane barges, and under all of it the green wet breath of the island itself, which never dries. We passed the slave pens behind the customs house, where the Company keeps its cargo between ships, and a man does well not to look too long into the dark of them, and I did not, and Bonesy did, the way he always does, because the dead and the soon-to-be-dead are the only company he has ever truly belonged to and he has never once pretended otherwise.

The tavern sat where the front street gives out, behind a chandlery, and it was the tavern, the one the whole outpost drinks in, because an outpost this size has room for one and no more. It was a Spanish building, from before the brethren made the island unfit for Spaniards, coral-rock walls two feet thick and beams of black hardwood overhead, and it had stood through more weather than the men in it had years between them. The hurricane that took the church roof three streets over had taken half the front street with it and left this building standing as if the storm had looked at it and thought better of the argument. Storms come through Tortuga every season

and knock down what the careless built, and every season this one is still here, and a man stops asking why and just drinks under it.

It was full, and loud, and the right sort of place, which is to say no one looked at Bonesy twice. That is the gift of the outpost and the whole reason a man like him can drink at all. Anywhere else a walking skeleton in a black hat is the end of days come walking in the door. Here he was maybe the fourth strangest thing on the floor, and falling.

Because the strange washes up in a place like this the way sea grass piles on a windward beach, a little more every tide, and the town has long since stopped stepping around it and learned to step over it instead. At a table near the back a ring of men were at cards, and the stake in the middle of them was not coin. It was a skull, small, yellow as old ivory, sitting on the boards in its own little cleared space the way a thing sits when men are half afraid to touch it. I have seen a dozen like it in a dozen such rooms. They all carry the same weight, that is the strange part, a heaviness that is not in the bone, a feeling when you hold one that you are holding something that knows you are holding it. Men will swear they have seen them burn with their own light at the dark of the moon. I have held them at the dark of the moon and seen nothing, and felt that weight the whole while, and put them down no surer than I picked them up. I have known good men go thin and strange chasing what a skull like that was supposed to do, sell their share and then their boat and then themselves to the want of it, and die no nearer an answer than the day they first held one. Whatever sits inside a thing like that, it has buried more men than it has ever answered.

And behind a rail and a curtain at the back, past a man you paid a coin to get by, was the other trade, the one the front of every port is built to feed. They had a woman back there who was not all the way

a woman, scales from the hip down gone grey and dull for want of the sea, got off some Dutchman who'd kept her in a tank on his foredeck. The men in the line did not stand in it because she was a wonder out of the oldest story sailors tell. They stood in it because she was strange and could not get up and leave, and there is a kind of man who will always pay the most for the thing that cannot walk away from him. The town had been handed a creature out of the deep mystery of the sea and found, without having to think about it, the one use it has for everything, which is to put a curtain in front of it and a coin on the other side of the curtain. That, more than the skull or the dice or Bonesy himself, is the truest strange thing in any of these places. Not that the sea throws up wonders. That men can stand in front of one and see only a thing to spend.

Bonesy considered the curtain as we crossed to our corner.

"Tail and all," he said, the scrape of it warm with the pleasure of his own joke, "and they've still found the one end of her that turns a coin. You have to admire a town that practical. A man could drown back there and die happy and they'd charge his shipmates for the water."

"You're a foul thing."

"I'm an honest thing. It's worse." He dropped onto the bench with his new hat and his new belt and the blade he had no use for, well pleased with himself. "Buy me a cup I can't drink, Jigsaw. I like to hold a thing while I watch other men make poor decisions."

So I bought a bottle of something brown that had been other things before it was rum, and a cup he could not drink from, and we took the corner.

We had not been in the corner long when I marked the one face in the room that did not belong to it.

Two tables off, a man sat alone with a cup he was not drinking. His face was too clean for the room. Not washed. Clean. The clean of skin kept soft on purpose, a jaw shaved that morning by careful hands, the face of a man who has never once hauled a wet line or stood a night watch in spray. You do not come by that face honestly in such a place. He had dressed it down, a sailor's coat, a sailor's slouch, the costume right in every part, but the face would not come down with the cloth, the way a ladyfish will throw itself clear of the water like a tarpon and fool you for half a breath, until you see the size of it and know exactly what you're looking at.

And when his eye crossed Bonesy it did a thing he could not stop, the way a lizard throws its throat at any shape that passes, no thought in it, only the old machinery underneath. Disgust, up out of him before he could sit on it, the look a devout man keeps for the thing his book has told him to hate. Then he caught it and smoothed it back down and was a tired sailor again, a man waiting on a tide.

A clean Spanish face in a French outpost. That alone would have been enough.

I set my cup down slow, and the trouble I worked out sitting there was not the trouble a man would guess. He had heard little. A skeleton going on about dead priests, which in that room is no more than the noise the room is made of, and somewhere in the easy run of it, that the other one of us had gone up the hill to see a Maya man about an old book. That was the whole of it. To him, a few random marks on a chart, no course in them yet. He was a set of ears and nothing more, sent to carry back whatever he caught for a cleverer head to read. It was no fault of Bonesy's. A man talks in a tavern. That is what a tavern is for. In any other port the words would have gone up the chimney with the smoke.

The trouble was the head he carried them to.

I have stood off Cárdenas's people twice, and the second time I went and learned what I could of the man they answered to, because a man who has nearly killed you twice is a man worth the reading. And what I learned is that he does not break a people and sail on. He keeps them. He keeps their books, the few the fires missed, and their gods in his cabinets, and their histories in his head, the whole shape of a thing he has spent a life unmaking, because you cannot truly finish a people until you understand them better than they understood themselves, and he means to finish them, so he understands them. He is the one Spaniard alive who could take a broken Maya book, and an old man newly dead who knew of it, and one of that old man's pupils gone up a hill to a Maya keeper, and lay those few stray marks on the chart and see the course run clean between them at a glance.

The spy had heard almost nothing. Cárdenas would see everything.

I leaned to Bonesy, who had gone quiet the moment my cup touched the wood, because for all that he never stops, he misses nothing.

"Clean Spanish face, two tables, your left," I said, low. "Don't turn. It's not what he heard. It's who he carries it to."

Bonesy did not turn his head.

"Cárdenas," he said. The scrape of it dropped almost to nothing.

"Cárdenas."

"And in this town we can't put a knife in him for it."

"No. We can't."

"I've never had much use for that law," Bonesy said, slow.

"It's the only roof these people have. We don't pull it down over one clean face. Sit."

He sat. And across the room the man rose, unhurried, the way they are taught, and laid a coin on his table too good for the rum, and

went out into the night up the same hill Crumble had gone up, where a clean Spanish face goes when it has something worth sending fast to an old master forty years at his trade.

And up that same hill, ahead of him, my brother was walking to the one man left on the earth who was a piece of Balam, not knowing he had grown a shadow the moment he turned off the front.

There was not one thing in the world the law would let me do about any of it.

*

I sat with it a while. A man goes up a hill. Another man goes up after him. I sit in a corner with a bottle of brown and the law of this place in my lap.

Bonesy let it run a good while. For him.

“You’ve gone quiet.”

“I have.”

He turned the cup he could not drink from, once, on the boards.

“You going up.”

“No.”

“Why.”

“Because he told me not to. Because I’d get there last.” The bottle had gone warm in my hand and I had not drunk from it. “And because I said an hour ago that the law was the only roof these people have.”

“That’s three.”

“It is.”

“Men with one reason go,” Bonesy said.

I did not answer that. I took the bottle out to the step, where I could see the hill.

There were lights coming down it. Four, evenly apart, holding the spacing where men walking home would have bunched and straggled. They had come out of the fort gate.

Bonesy came out behind me. He does not breathe, so there is never any warning.

"Soldiers."

"Soldiers."

"In this town." He said it slow. "Coming down."

"Cárdenas has bought the garrison," I said. "And the law with it."

Bonesy was quiet a moment. "That fast."

"The clean face went up an hour ago."

"I said I never had much use for that law."

"You did."

"I've a use for it now."

Above the lanterns the hill went black where the trees start. I stood and looked at the black for longer than I had to spare. Bonesy stood beside me and said nothing, which he can keep up about as long as a man can hold his breath.

"He'll come down to the water," he said.

"He'll come down to the water."

"Then we want to be on it."

We went down to the water at a walk. A man running on that street turns every head on it, and I did not want those heads going up the hill yet.

She lay where we had left her, bow out, with the last of the evening's buying still on the stones beside her. The pork was aboard. The powder was aboard, because powder goes aboard first. What stood on the stones was the breaker of water, and the netted sack of oranges, and a coil of good hemp none of us had got to.

A full breaker wants two men at the stones and a third at the rail, and we had no third.

“I can get it aboard,” Bonesy said.

“How long.”

He looked at it a moment. He did not lie to me.

“Longer than you’ll want to give me.”

“Then leave it.”

He left it. He put the oranges over the rail and left the water standing on the stones, and I have thought about that breaker more since than I have thought about most men I have killed.

They came off the hill and onto the head of the front street and stopped.

Men were already coming out behind them. Out of the tavern, off the decks along the quay, out of the chandlery with the door still going. Nobody drew. They came out with their cups in their hands and stood on the stones and looked up the street, and there got to be a great many of them, and the four lights stayed where they were.

One of the Frenchmen lifted his lantern to put it on a face and lowered it again.

They did not come past the chandlery.

We got her lines singled and I took the tiller and we did not go.

The tide was making. I had until it turned and a little after, and past that the gap out by the point goes foul and stays foul till morning.

I worked it out three times. The answer did not move. I worked it out again.

“He’s coming,” Bonesy said.

I did not answer.

“Jigsaw.”

“I heard you.”

He let it sit. Then, quieter than he goes: “You’ve done the sum.”

“I’ve done it.”

“How long.”

I told him. Bonesy, who has never once run out of talk, did not say anything.

I gave the tide away. I gave it all the way away, past the sum and out the other side of it.

He did not come down the street. I had been watching the street.

He came along the water from the west, out of the dark past the last of the storehouses. He was wet to the thigh. He had Balam’s blade still in his hand and nothing else in it.

I put my hand out and took his wrist and got him over the rail, and I did not let go of the wrist as quick as I might have.

Bonesy looked past him, back up the water the way he had come, for a good while after there was any use in looking.

Crumble went forward and put his hand on the cable.

“Let her go,” he said.

We went out on the last of it. The gap by the point let us through with water under her. The breaker stood on the quay where we had left it, pale on the dark stones, and it was standing there still when the town went behind the point.

Above the town the lights had gone back up the hill and into the fort, in the same order they came down in.

CHAPTER 3

The Cay

It was a long while before anyone spoke. The outpost shrank astern to a scatter of lamps and then to nothing.

“Domingo,” I said. Not a question.

“In the trees above the town. He’d not meet me anywhere with walls.” Crumble had his eyes on the water ahead. “Garrison came straight up the path. Somebody sold the meeting before it happened.”

“And you got out.”

“Put a smoke down and went into the green. Domingo stood up out of it so they’d have a man to take.” His hands stayed easy on the tiller. “Last I saw, they had him on his knees and the Spaniard in the clean coat was looking at the trees. Right at them.” He let a breath out. “So I came down to the boat.”

I did not tell him he was right to leave. He knew he was right to. There is nothing crueler you can tell a man than that he was right to leave his friend on his knees in the dark, and nothing truer, so I said neither, and let the wind have it.

“You get what you went for?” Bonesy said. He’d come aft from the cable, the new hat a black shape against the stars.

“Part of it. It’s real, and it’s broken, and the pieces run in a line, like the marks on a chart. The cave off Jigsaw’s island is the first mark. Find it right and it sets you the bearing to the next.”

“And he gave you that bearing?”

“He was getting to it in the trees when the garrison came up the path.”

So we had the first mark and no leg drawn past it, and the one man who could have laid the rest of the course was on his knees in Tortuga. Bonesy looked back the way we’d come, north and east, where the lamps had been.

“They’ll not sit on that long,” he said. “A man like the one you’ve drawn, he’ll have a hull behind us by the morning watch.”

“Let them,” Crumble said. “Nobody on this sea catches her with a clean bottom and a fair wind.”

“They will if it blows,” I said. “We run from weather. The kind of ship he’ll send—”

“Sails straight through it,” Bonesy said. He said it lightly, the way he says the things that aren’t, and took the weight of it off me, which is a thing he does more often than I let on.

Nobody answered that. There was nothing to answer. It went into the boat with the rest of the night’s weight and we left it there.

“We’ll be thirsty before any of it,” I said, to put us back on a thing we could mend. “We left the water on the quay. A day aboard, maybe less.”

“There’s the cacao,” Crumble said.

The pressed tablets the Mayans carried, that he’d had the sense to lay in. It would keep us standing if it kept us nothing else, and tasted, he allowed, like the scrapings off a wet deck. But cacao is dry, and a

man cannot drink it dry.

“We water before the island. Off the run, nowhere they’ll watch.” I ran the cays in my head, which held and which went dry. “There’s a string of low ones west and south. Most are sand and nothing. But there’s one the reef wraps the whole windward face of, and that one I never made, the gap looked mean and I had water enough at the time not to chance it.”

“The one with the palms standing in a hook,” Bonesy said.

I looked at him.

“I’ve been to it.”

He has been to nearly every scrap of land in this sea and remembers almost none of them. The ones he keeps are not the ones where men took him in, because men never did. A walking dead thing is the first over the side when a boat runs short, and he has been put over the side of more boats than I’ve sailed. What he keeps is the stone. A face in a wall that did not decide he was expendable, that did not leave.

“There’s a spring behind the rocks at the back,” he said. “And a face the old people cut over it. Ixchel. I sat with her a season once.” A beat. “Worse company than Beatriz, and Beatriz is a post.”

“Then the water’s clean,” Crumble said. “The Mayans cut a face over a spring to mark it safe.”

So between us we had it. My reckoning of the reef and his of the stone. One gap in that windward face, the surge standing in it like a wall, a boat through at first light or not at all. She’d go through. I’d put her through. I kept the rest in my head.

I took the first watch. Crumble would not sleep and Bonesy never does, and so we went on three men awake on a small boat, the way we’d come in, lighter by all our water and heavier by everything else, and one eye, all of us now, on the dark astern.

*

Bonesy lasted until the lamps of Tortuga were down under the sea behind us, and not a breath past it.

He folded onto the thwart across from Crumble and tipped the new hat back off his brow with one finger, easy, a man settling in to enjoy himself.

“You’re good at that, aren’t you,” he said. “Leaving a fellow behind.”

“I know what I did.”

“Not scolding. Some men can’t do it at all. You don’t even slow down.”

Crumble worked the leaf and said nothing, which in him is an answer.

A man taken in the dark is a small thing to Bonesy, and you sit with him a while before you see why. He has watched the short-lived get hauled off and drowned and hung for nine hundred years, and from where he stands we all fetch up in the same harbor soon enough, the only question the hour of it. He is not standing close enough to the loss to feel its size. The rest of us have no choice but to.

“He’d not meet me anywhere with walls,” Crumble said. “His choosing.”

“Sure it was. Who’d you leave the first time.”

He said nothing.

Bonesy knew most of it already. A year in a small boat and he had all our headlines whether we handed them over or not. He was not after the story. He likes to lay a finger on a sore place and feel it jump, the way a boy presses a bruise to know it’s still his.

“Come on. The girl.”

“You know about the girl.”

“I like to hear you say her.”

Crumble took a turn off the sheet that did not need taking and made it fast. “Ixmal,” he said. The old name, the one Balam’s people gave a child born in a hard season, that means something near enough to bear. “A town. I was sixteen and a crew would have me.”

“And you went.”

“And I went.”

“Quick about it, were you.”

“Quick about everything, then.” He turned the leaf. That was all he gave it, and it was more than he gives most.

What he did not say, I knew, and it sat in the boat under the little he did say, the way the deep part of a channel sits under the bright of it. The sea was the largest thing a boy of sixteen had ever stood beside, and a girl in a town is a small steady light against a whole horizon, and he chose the horizon, the way he was always going to. She did not go to ruin after. She married and grew children and a good life in the exact place he had stood, closed over the hole of him without a mark, and that is the wound. Not that he hurt her. That she could do without him so clean. Mine runs the other way and comes to the same water. We have never set the two side by side and named them the one thing, and they are no more the same than the water in a spring and the water in the sea, and no less, and a man dying of thirst in a boat learns the difference is the whole of everything.

“So now you put nothing down,” Bonesy said, light still, but in. “Promises. Dead men’s errands.”

“That’s loyalty.”

“That’s paying.”

Crumble took the chart from under his coat and held it without unrolling it, which is the most of an answer Bonesy was going to get,

and we all knew it, and it went into the boat with the rest of the night's weight and we left it.

The thirst was bad by full light and the hunger under it worse. Want makes a man quiet. It sits in him and sands him down, and by midmorning the only one of us in any humour was the one with no belly to ache.

"Try wanting nothing," Bonesy said, watching us not eat. "Gave it up ages back. Light as a gull."

"You want a hat."

"Got the hat."

I put a handline over and trolled it on the quarter while the cay came up green and low, and short of noon a little tunny took it. Crumble bled him over the side and we ate him raw and warm. It gives a man back a little but never the thing he's after, the salt of a fish only sharpening the want of clean water down the line. It steadied us. Enough to think with.

Bonesy watched us eat, the way he watches everything we do with our mouths, like a man at the border of a country he'll never hold papers for.

"You went back," he said to Crumble. Not a question.

Crumble's hands kept on the fish.

"Once."

"And."

"There was no room in her life the size of me." He flicked the bones over. "Came home."

That was the whole of it, four words doing the work of a year of standing in the trees, and Bonesy let them, because even he knows when a man has handed over the true thing and there's no call to press it flatter.

*

Which was when I looked astern, the way I had since Tortuga without rightly stopping, and at the hard rim of the sea where there had been nothing all morning, there was a sail.

I watched it to be sure. A tired eye builds ships out of haze. But it held, too much canvas for the easy wind, a hull driven and not sailed, standing off no honest business of its own.

We had known he sent it. That much we carried out of Tortuga for certain, that the man does not wait on weather the way we do, that a hull built to cut right through a storm the way a sword tears through flesh.

“There he is,” Bonesy said, almost fond, the way he greets what the rest of us dread.

And dead ahead, low and green and ringed all round with bright shoal water, the cay came on, and the one mean gate in it, and behind the gate the only water for sixty miles that would not kill us.

The gate did not look like a gate. It looked like a wide bright road in. That is the trick of clear water, and it has drowned more men than rough water ever has. Rough water frightens a man honest. Clear water lies to him sweet. I read the reef off the colour of it, the dark green that is depth and the brown green that is a coral head a foot down. There was one way into that cove, the way there is one gap in a fence a fox can take, and we barely made it.

The cay sat low and green ahead. A hook of palms, and behind them other trees climbing higher, all of them competing for the sun, a jungle island shouldering up out of the sea. A beach under the palms the colour of bone. No track on it, no fire-black, no mark of a boat ever drawn up.

As we rounded into the cove we dropped the anchor. The water was warm as blood, and we went over the side and swam in.

Bonesy went up the sand ahead of us, skipping, a choirboy let out of the cathedral early.

“Mind the wet rocks,” he sang out.

Behind the rocks the spring came out of a low grey face of stone, and over it the Mayans had cut a woman, worn near to nothing, only the line of the nose and a closed and patient eye. Bonesy stopped and caressed her face.

“I spent many years with this one,” he said.

“She’s a rock, Bonesy.”

“It’s almost a good thing she can’t talk.”

We got down to the stone and put our faces to the water and drank like a Tortuga cur drinks from the gutter after it rains. No shame in it.

When I sat back I looked out past the reef. She was there. She had come up while we drank, topsails to the mast, riding easy. Not coming on. Not firing. Just waiting, the way a barracuda waits, hung still in the water with everything in it pointed at you, patient because it knows it is faster than the thing it means to have.

“Two days dry and you forget there’s a King’s ship come to take you off in irons,” Bonesy said, watching us watch her.

Crumble looked at me. I looked at him, and both of us were in the same place at once. Twenty men against the two of us, three years back, in a cove much like this one. Only two remained to tell the tale.

The smile got away from me before I could stop it. Crumble’s mouth did the same.

“What,” Bonesy said. “What. I miss things, being dead. What is it.”

“High ground,” I said, and got up.

The high ground was a shelf of broken rock above the spring, screened by scrub, with a clean line out past the reef to the deep blue where she lay. We went up on our bellies the last of it and lay in the scrub and watched.

She was busy now. The easy riding was gone out of her, the sails hauled up and hanging slack against her masts as the men worked the falls, and the long shape of a boat swung out on her davits, slow against the bright water.

“Rowboat,” Crumble said.

“Aye.”

A crew at the oars, armed to the teeth. The reef that wrecked a hull was an open invitation to a boat drawing two feet.

That was the trouble, and it sat us both back on our heels. Three years gone, the pirate had brought his whole ship in after us, fat and sure as a pig walking itself to the butcher knife, run her into the cove on his own arrogance, and we had only to be there and let the ground do the rest. It had been easy. This was a different man.

Bonesy watched our faces and smiled, the way he smiled the last time me and Crumble ran aground.

“You weren’t expecting him to drop a rowboat in, were you,” he said.

Neither of us answered.

But a day from now there would be two more ships among us. After a day, a whole fleet. The hunt had gone out the moment the finger left the box, and every hour we sat here it drew its net a little tighter.

Crumble looked at me. I looked at him. The only way that ship came onto the rocks was if the man at her helm stopped thinking. You have to take it from him. You have to make him feel he has no choice. You have to take the choice from him the way you take it

from a slave, leave him nothing in his hands but the one road you've left open, and watch him walk it thinking it was his own feet that chose.

*

The boat came in on the slack water with the oars dipping easy, ten men in her, the morning sun bright on the steel they'd brought to take three tired pirates off a rock. They came the way a dog comes for a thrown bone, sure of the having, eyes on nothing but the prize. They did not look up.

The cove was ringed in palms that lean out over the water, and a man in the crook of one is a shadow among shadows to an eye fixed on the beach, and I had been in mine since before they cleared the slot. I watched the boat come under me. The bald spot on the bow oar, the soft clean neck of the one in the stern sheets who wore his coat better than the rest. I let them slide in under the tree. I let the bow grate on the sand.

Then I came down on them out of the green.

I took the steersman first. I came down with the whole weight of the drop behind the upper sword and drove it in at the join of his neck and shoulder, down through the meat of him, and felt it grate and stop on bone deep in his chest. He folded over it. The blade was stuck and I put my boot on his shoulder and tore it free and the wound opened and gave up its dark wash down his front, and he went into the bilge thrashing, heels drumming the boards.

There is no art to it, in a boat. A boat is a pen. Men in a boat cannot run, cannot get round you, cannot bring their numbers to bear. They can only stand up into the thing killing them, one and one and one, and a man standing up in a rocking boat is a man handing you

his belly. The next one came up with his cutlass half drawn and I took the hand off at the wrist before the steel cleared the scabbard, clean, the hand dropping with the hilt still in its grip, and he stood a moment staring at the stump pumping bright into the sun before I put the point under his jaw and up. He bit down on the blade as it went through. I felt his teeth shut on the steel.

The man behind him slipped in his fellow's blood and went down to one knee in the bilge, and I brought the pommel of the lower sword across his temple and the bone gave with a wet crack and his eye started from the socket, and he pitched forward over the thwart and lay with his legs still in the dead steersman's lap, twitching. Another came at me low with a bayonet and laid the back of my forearm open, and I let him have the arm and took his throat with the short blade, sawed it, felt the gristle of the windpipe part under the edge, and turned him loose to drown in the sound he was making.

Crumble came in over the bow with Balam's blade. He took a man through the kidney from behind and ripped sideways, the way you gut a fish, and the man came apart at the middle and sat down in what came out of him, holding it, trying to gather it back. Another swung an oar at Crumble's head and Crumble ducked it and opened his thigh to the bone and left him to fall, and he fell screaming, both hands jammed in the wound and the blood coming through his fingers in ropes.

"BEAUTIFUL," Bonesy was howling from the rocks, up on his feet, clapping his hard hands together with a sound like stones knocked. "Oh, the LEFT one, Crumble, mind the left, there's a — yes! YES! Down he goes! Did you see it!"

It was a butchering. I will set it down as that, because I have heard men call these things fights after, and they lie to make themselves easier to live with. We closed the boat from both ends

toward the middle and killed them in it with the sun on the water, and one we did not finish clean, a young one, gut-cut and folded over the thwart still moving, and I took him by the collar and the belt and pitched him over the side into the lagoon to bleed out where he wouldn't be underfoot, and he went down in a slow red bloom with the little fish already rising to him. The cove that had not heard a human sound in a hundred years heard all of it.

And we kept two.

That was the cold part, the part we'd settled on the rock with a look and no words. The soft-necked officer. And one big slow oarsman who'd dropped his blade and thrown his hands up, which on another morning might have bought him something. A dead man goes down and is a number. A live one works at the surface a long while, and the man with the glass to his eye cannot put it down. We bound them.

Bonesy came down off the rocks and crouched in front of the two of them, his skull a hand's width from their faces, and looked them over the way you'd look over fish on a market slab.

"Hello, fellas."

The rest we hauled up. Crumble took the shoulders and I took the feet and we carried the dead up off the sand to the high shelf one by one, seven of them, and set them in a row along the lip where the line was clean to the sea.

"Then let's give him something to watch," said Crumble.

We put them in the water. Not together. One, and a count, and the next, the way you pay out a line you mean a man to watch running. Each went off the lip and struck and went under and came up turning. The current along the face took them out slow. By the fourth there was a string of them standing away from the rock in good order, and a man a half mile off with a glass to his eye would have no trouble at

all counting what was left of the boat he'd sent.

Then the two.

I went to the oarsman first. He was crying. I cut the back of both his knees and stood him up and put my boot to him, and he went off the lip with his arms going.

The officer did not cry. He watched me come the way a fish holds still when a heron's shadow crosses the water above it, still because still is all that is left to it. I cut the back of both his knees and stood him up and put my boot to him.

He went in screaming. The coat filled with water and dragged him and he came up anyway, both hands beating at the surface, the ruined legs trailing dark behind him. He got his chin up once. Went under. Came up again with less in it. The coat took him on the third.

I heard him stop. The oarsman went on a while after that, out past the string of the dead, and then he did not.

I was already cleaning the blade.

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She took the bait. We had made it ugly enough that the captain could not stay out in deep water and watch. His whole boat crew was in the water below the rock now, drifting in a red bloom, the small fish already rising to them and the bigger fish under those. He brought her in.

She came in fast, too fast for water like that. She found the deep channel and ran it a while, then lost it. Her keel went up onto the coral and stuck, and she hung there with her bow into the cove and her stern swinging slow on the swell, caught in the reef the way a fish hangs in a weir.

Bonesy had already gone back to the sloop. He got to the one gun and laid it while she was still settling, and when she came to rest he had her whole deck open below him. The first ball went in at the bow and walked the length of her, the rail going to splinters, men going down.

That was our door.

Every face aboard turned forward to the smoke and the wreck of the bow, and that was when Crumble and I came off the cliff.

The masthead stood level with the rock where we crouched, near enough to touch. Crumble went first. He caught the topmast shroud where it ran up to the cap and went down it hand under hand, quiet, his feet barely touching the rope. I came after. We came down the rigging into the smoke with the whole crew's backs to us, four pistols apiece across our chests, and dropped onto the deck behind them.

No one had looked up. The bow was smoke and splinters, and every eye was on it.

A barracuda does its waiting before the rush. After that there is only the flash of it, and the water opening red behind.

We had waited long enough.

I set the first pistol to the nearest back and fired. The shot went through him and found the sailor in front of him, and both dropped into the smoke. Crumble fired twice beside me. Two more went down before the deck understood the trouble had come from behind.

Then they turned.

Badly. Some toward me, some toward Crumble, some back toward the bow as if the first trouble were still the only one. Smoke had them by the eyes. Fire had them by the backs. The reef had the ship by the belly. We were in the one place no one had guarded.

I drew both blades.

The first sailor came at me wide, cutlass high. I stepped inside the swing and put one blade under his arm, the other across the back of his knee as I passed. He folded wrong, one half of him still trying to stand and the other half finished with the matter.

The next had a pistol halfway out. I cut across his hand before he cleared it. The pistol dropped with three fingers still curled around it. He looked down, slow with shock, and I put the other blade under his jaw. His teeth shut on the steel. I felt it in the grip.

Crumble was on the other side of the smoke with Balam's blade low in his hand. He does not fight pretty. He fights like a snare taking shut. A sailor swung an axe at him. Crumble stepped inside it, caught the wrist on the way down, and opened him from hip to ribs. The axe hit the boards after its owner did.

After that the deck went slick.

Blood does not stay where it falls on a ship. It runs with the tilt, finds seams, gets under your feet. The smoke rolled back from the bow in hot sheets, and the killing went half blind. Shapes came at us and we cut them down. One slipped before he reached me and rose on one knee, which was high enough. Another backed into the broken rail and put his hand into a nest of hot splinters. He looked at the hand. I opened him.

Someone called for the captain. Someone else called for God.

Neither came quick enough.

We pushed them toward the middle of the deck. Crumble from one side, me from the other. Not clean work. Deck work never is. Too close, too loud, too much footing to lose. A sailor would come out of smoke with his mouth open and be dead before he had shaped a word. Another would swing at where I had been and find Crumble instead. The ship bucked under us on the reef, each swell lifting her and setting her down harder, so the wounded slid with the blood and

the dead shifted as if they had been called back to their stations.

A sailor came out of the smoke with a boarding pike. I caught the shaft between both blades, turned it, and drove my shoulder into him. He went back against the rail. I put one blade through his belly and pinned him there long enough to take the pike from his hands.

The smoke thinned.

The deck opened in front of me, and the captain was there.

He stood at the break of the quarterdeck with his coat off and his sleeves rolled back, a long Spanish blade low at his side. He had not rushed with the rest. He had watched them die and used the time well.

I hated him for that first.

He had the look of the boys from the clean rooms. Not soft now. The sea had taken some of that off him. But he had been soft once. Fed once. Named once. The kind of face that had never had to ask the world for room.

Then he lifted the blade, and I knew the school in his wrist.

He came in without hurry.

The first touch told me he was good. The second told me I could die there.

He did not spend himself. That was the worst of it. Anger gives you handles. Fear gives you gaps. Pride makes a fool reach too far. He gave me none of that. His point stayed in the middle of me, patient as a hook in deep water, and his feet took the deck a little at a time.

So I gave ground.

Past the mast. Past a body rolling under my heel. Past the smoke blowing hot from the bow. I had both blades moving and still he made me work harder than I liked. Every time I tried to turn him, he was there. Every time I tried to crowd him, his point was waiting in

the road.

Crumble had his own work. I saw him only in pieces. The red sash through smoke. Balam's blade rising and falling. A man going down with both hands at his throat. Then the captain took the sight from me again.

He pressed me back toward the broken rail.

The cove was below. Fire to my left. Smoke to my right. His blade in front, already measuring the place under my breastbone.

Then his mouth changed.

Not a smile. He knew better than to smile. Only the smallest easing at the corner, as if the deck had righted under him, as if the dirty sailor in hides had remembered where he belonged.

That was when I knew what I hated in him.

A proper master would have been proud of him. That was his trouble. Proper masters teach a man to beat another proper man. Same floors. Same rules. Same clean lies.

I let my left blade catch his.

Not hard. Not desperate. Just enough to look like a mistake. He felt the bind and took it, because it was the right thing to take. His strength came forward. His eye went with it. For one breath, all of him belonged to my left hand.

My right went under.

No flourish. No lesson. Just the short ugly thrust from rooms where nobody was trying to become a gentleman.

The blade went up beneath his jaw and stopped deep.

The captain froze.

His sword fell out of his hand and struck the deck once.

He looked surprised. Not hurt yet. Not afraid. Only surprised, as if the world had broken a promise it had been keeping with him all his life.

I held him there a moment.

I wanted him to know it had not been reef, or smoke, or luck.

Me.

Then I drew the blade out and let him down.

The fight went out of the ship with him. There were still bodies moving. Still breath catching wet where it should not. Still Crumble standing in the smoke with Balam's blade dark to the grip. But the ship knew. You can feel it when a crew is finished. The noise changes. The living start listening for permission to stay that way.

Out past the rail, the cove had gone red. The fish were rising through it.

CHAPTER 4

The Half Moon

The sharks were in the cove by the middle of the morning. They had come in through the gap on the flood and they did not leave. By the second hour we had stopped looking.

She was bilged forward and settled by the head, and her stern swung a little on every swell, working herself on the coral. She was going to come apart there whatever anybody did. So we took what would come off her, and we took it fast.

Powder in the dry cask. Shot for the one gun. Biscuit, a cask of salt beef gone over but not gone, cordage, canvas, a spare set of blocks, and a copper kettle Bonesy took a liking to that nobody argued about. Her glass, which was better than ours by a long way. Her charts, which were Spanish and careful and worth more than the rest of it together.

We took the water last and we took it slow. The spring under Ixchel came out of the rock the thickness of a man's finger and would not be hurried, and we stood a man at it in turn through the afternoon

and into the dark, filling what we had.

“He'll know where we were,” Crumble said. He was on the stones with the chart across his knees and had not unrolled it yet.

“He'll know we took her with three.”

Crumble looked out at the wreck a while.

“Then the next one won't come in a boat.”

We went out through the gap on the morning tide with the cove behind us going about its business, and we did not look at that either.

It was eleven days west and south.

Eleven days is long enough that a boat stops being a boat and turns into a room three men cannot leave. Crumble had the tiller more than his share of it. Bonesy talked. I read the Spanish charts, which were better than anything I had ever had under my hand, and found on the third day that I had read the same soundings four times and could not have said what they were.

“Your pool,” Bonesy said.

“What about it.”

He let that sit a while.

“You never went in.”

“No.”

“Why.”

I did not give him one. He let it go, which he does about as often as a squall turns back.

What I had not said in the temple, and did not say on that deck, is that the pool had been mine for five years because I had not gone into it. I could take it out on a bad watch and look at it and put it back the way it was. I had been living off it the way a crew lives off a cask nobody has broached. Now Domingo was in a Spanish room somewhere with the rest of the course in his head, and the pool was the only road the three of us had.

Crumble did not ask for days. Then he asked.

“Jigsaw.”

“I know.”

“I've not said anything.”

“You've been going to since the cay.”

He shifted the tiller a hair to feel the wind.

“How sure are you of the water pulling.”

“Sure.”

“Sure the way a man is sure. Or sure the way you're sure of a current.”

“The second.”

He nodded and let it alone. That was the whole of what either of us said about the fact that everything we had left was a pool I had got out of at twenty and rowed away from.

On the ninth day Bonesy asked whether there was stone on it. I told him there was not, that I had seen none. He took it the way a man takes bad weather he has no say in, and did not ask again.

On the eleventh we raised it. It came up off the bow low and long and bent at the middle, green at the two ends and pale in the bight of it, the shape a man's thumb and finger make when he holds something small he does not want to crush.

I had it in my hands for the better part of an hour before Crumble said anything about the glass.

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There is no landing on the windward side. The swell comes the whole width of the sea to get at it and it arrives the way it has been arriving since before anybody was here to watch. We brought her round into the lee and let the anchor go on sand in three fathoms and

walked over.

It is not far. A half mile of low scrub that takes the skin off a man's forearms and does not apologise, and then the ground lifts into grey rock scoured bare, and the noise of the other side comes up over it before you see any of it.

Bonesy went up the last of the rock first because he does not tire and it costs him nothing to be told to wait. He stood on the top of it with the wind taking the brim of his hat flat back off his skull and looked down the far side a long moment.

“Oh,” he said.

The pool sits in the rock about a cable in from the break, in a shelf the sea only gets into on the worst days. It is thirty feet across and no shape that means anything. The rock around it is scoured pale and there is nothing living on it, no weed, no crab, nothing that wants to be there. The water is so clear that the first time a man looks he takes it for empty.

Then it moves.

They were in it. Six of them, and one over seven feet that I remembered and had half talked myself out of remembering. They went round the pool one behind the other on the current, slow, not working at it. The great plate scales of them went from grey to white to nothing as they turned through the light. A tarpon the length of a man does not look like a fish in three feet of water. It looks like something that has come up out of where it belongs to see what is being said about it.

Crumble came up beside me and stopped.

“You said six and seven feet.”

“I did.”

“You undersold it.”

I went down the rock and crouched at the edge where I had crouched before, and put my hand in the water to the wrist.

They came round. The big one came first and did not turn off. He went past my hand close enough that I felt the water he pushed. He went past it slow. The eye of him came round as he came and stayed on me the whole length of his body, and then the tail went by and the water closed and he was round the far side and coming again.

“He's had a look at you,” Bonesy said from up on the rock.

“He has.”

“What did he make of it.”

“He's not said.”

I kept my hand in the water. I had done exactly this at twenty and had got up afterwards and walked back over the scrub and rowed away, and I had spent five years telling the story to myself and to nobody else. Now Bonesy was up on the rock with his hat in his fist so the wind would not have it, and Crumble was standing over me with Balam's blade on his hip and a Spanish chart in his coat, and it was not mine any more.

Crumble crouched. He did not put his hand in. He watched the water for a while instead, and I let him do it, because there is nobody alive I would rather have read it after me.

“It's pulling,” he said.

“It is.”

“Pool this size in bare rock. No weed in it, no crab, and the water going round like that.” He put two fingers in at last, just the ends of them, and took them out. “There's no wind on it. There's no wave getting in. Nothing turns water in a hole in a rock for nothing.”

“No.”

He looked across at the low side of the shelf, where the rock goes down under the pool and the light stops.

“Where does it go.”
“I never found out,” I said.